

Zomato's health features are well-built and still don't work — here's why

A full 8-stage teardown of Zomato's order placement and Healthy flow: framed, mapped, walked, zoned, intent-tagged, steelmanned, rebuilt, and prioritised.

Product Teardown

Consumer / Food-Tech

Domain-Led Analysis

Anubhav Kapoor

Zomato **Order placement → Healthy tab → Gold checkout** **17 screens, own account**
Product Flow torn down Evidence

Self-initiated, Sept 2026

Not a course submission

READ THIS FIRST — 60-SECOND SUMMARY

THE QUESTION

Zomato has calorie counts and a Healthy tab. Does it help someone eat toward *their own* goal — or does it just label food, the same way for everyone?

WHY I CAN ANSWER THIS PROPERLY

B.Pharm, run a nutrition business, and already built **NutriLens AI** — a computer-vision app that estimates meal macros from a photo. This is a problem I've built a product around before.

WHAT I FOUND

The health feature is more sophisticated than expected — but it's **siloes in a tab most orders never touch**, it's **not personalised** to any individual, and its nutrition data **breaks under real-world customisation** — proven on a live order, not argued from theory.

THE BUSINESS TENSION MOST TEARDOWNS SKIP

Zomato is paid on order frequency. A feature that genuinely helps someone eat well can reduce how often they order. That conflict is why this isn't a simple "just add the feature" fix.

MY RECOMMENDATION

Don't rebuild — reuse. Surface the macro data Zomato already computes onto the default Home feed, and add a one-time goal input that reweights the existing score. Full reasoning below.

WHY THIS EXISTS

Most teardowns stop at "the filter doesn't work"

Every generic teardown of a food delivery app reaches for checkout friction or search speed — the same three observations every candidate makes. I wanted to write the version that only shows up with a health-science background behind it.

The idea to hold onto through everything below: **"healthy" is not a fixed property of a dish.** It's a relationship between a dish, a person, and that person's goal on that particular day. A butter chicken is a good call for someone on a muscle-gain surplus and a bad one for someone managing a deficit — same dish, opposite answer, depending only on who's asking. A food app that shows one "Healthy" badge to every user has already lost that distinction before it recommends anything.

STAGE 1 · FRAME THE TEARDOWN

What I set out to test — and where I was wrong

Before opening the app, I wrote down a hypothesis: *the Healthy filter is a broken keyword match that tags things "healthy" when they clearly aren't.* I expected to spend this whole case study proving that.

I was wrong, and I'd rather say so directly than quietly edit the thesis to fit — a teardown that only confirms what you assumed going in isn't analysis, it's confirmation bias. The feature turned out to be well-built. The real problem sits somewhere else, and it only shows up once you look past the surface.

Goal — evaluate a specific feature bet: is Zomato's health/nutrition layer goal-aware, or is it goal-agnostic labelling wearing a personalised interface?

User — a health-conscious orderer tracking calories, protein, or macros against a personal target — a deficit, a muscle-gain surplus, or a medical dietary constraint — deciding what to order for dinner tonight.

Job to be done — not "help me find healthy food" (too generic to explain any interface decision) but "help me order something that still fits my target today, without having to do the math myself." That second framing is what explains why a macro number at the point of decision matters more than a general "healthy" label.

"I remember once I was ordering dinner and I saw a paneer bowl, and the menu said 30g protein. I called the restaurant and asked — is this 30g protein for the whole bowl? They said yes. Then I asked how much paneer is actually in it. They said around 80 to 100 grams, 'think so.' I asked if the rice and dressing were included in that calculation. They said yes, 'I think so.' ... Since then I don't completely depend on the numbers written on a menu. I look at the actual portion, ingredients, and how the food is cooked."

— a client I work with on a structured nutrition plan, six months in

This isn't a hypothetical risk. It's the exact failure mode Stage 4.4 below documents on my own order — a platform-shown number that doesn't survive contact with the actual dish.

I asked five people, independently, whether they trust the calorie or protein numbers these apps show. None of them fully did — for five different reasons, none of them prompted by the others. That's no longer one person's story. It's the baseline this teardown starts from.

STAGE 2 · MAP THE BUSINESS

Why this isn't a simple "just add the feature" fix

Zomato's core loop is order frequency × average order value, monetised through commission, delivery fees, Gold subscription, and restaurant advertising. Every growth number the company reports ladders up to "more people, ordering more often." That matters here, because a health feature done properly can work against that loop.

If a goal-aware nutrition layer actually works, it will sometimes tell a user: *"you've already hit your target today."* That's a nudge toward ordering less, not more — a direct structural

conflict with the metric the business runs on, and the single most important thing a generic teardown misses.

METRIC LAYER	MY INFERENCE	WHAT IT'S BASED ON	CONFIDENCE
North star	Orders × AOV, per active user	Standard delivery-platform economics; discount and coupon mechanics visible throughout checkout are all frequency/AOV levers	M
L1	Gold subscriber retention; order frequency per cohort	The prominence of "you saved ₹X with Gold" at every checkout suggests Gold retention is actively tracked and reinforced	M
L2	Healthy-tab session-to-order conversion	The tab's investment (curated rails, macro browse, ingredient reasoning) implies it's measured as its own funnel, separate from Home	L
Guardrail	Overall order frequency must not drop when health features are shown more prominently	Inferred from the structural tension above — a rational team would guardrail against this before expanding the feature's reach	L

THE TENSION, STATED PLAINLY

A feature that helps someone eat well can reduce how often they order. Any pitch for a "healthy layer" that doesn't confront this hasn't understood the business it's proposing to change.

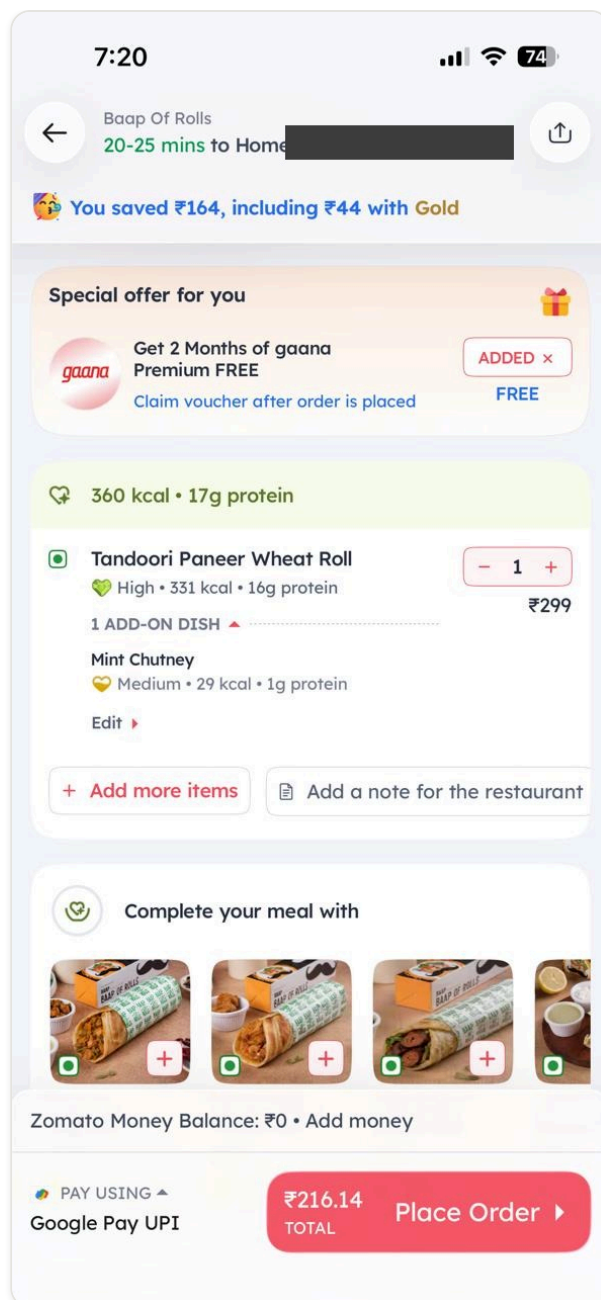
The pitch that survives a leadership review has to be built in two separate steps, not blurred into one. **First:** this feature will not increase order frequency, and may reduce it for some users — so it should never be pitched on a frequency or GMV upside, since the platform's commission structure doesn't reward one dish category over another. **Second:** it earns its keep through Gold retention and long-term trust — a health-conscious user who trusts the platform to genuinely support their goal is a user who doesn't churn to a competitor the week they start a diet. That's a retention argument, not a revenue one, and it needs to be

sized and pitched as exactly that, with a real model of retained-user value against churned-user value before anyone commits budget to it.

"It feels like an overpriced 'health tax' that pushes ₹350+ cold salads and Western diet bowls instead of simple, affordable local meals like dal and roti."

— Raju, on the Healthy tab's pricing and menu

There's a business-model consequence hiding inside that quote that's easy to miss. If "healthy" is consistently the premium-priced, Western-coded option, the feature isn't just failing to reach Tier 2/3 markets on rollout (see the market-context note below) — it may be actively signalling "not for you" to a large share of price-sensitive users even where it has launched. A goal-aware layer built on dal, roti, and sabzi at everyday prices is a different, and arguably harder, product to build than a salad-and-protein-bowl rail — but it's the version that would actually reach most of the country.



Checkout on a Healthy-tagged item: "You saved ₹164, including ₹44 with Gold" — directly above a free Gaana Premium cross-sell. The health framing and the growth mechanics sit on the same screen, competing for the same attention.

A market-context check

Worth stating plainly, since it changes how far any of this actually reaches: Healthy Mode is not available everywhere. It launched first in Gurugram, and as of the most recent public coverage, the newer Healthy Subscriptions layer is live only in Delhi NCR, Mumbai, and Bengaluru — three metro markets. I confirmed this directly: switching my delivery location from Ghaziabad (NCR) to Mathura, the Healthy tab disappears from the bottom navigation entirely, replaced by a plain "History" tab. Every finding in this teardown assumes the feature exists at all. In most of the country, right now, it doesn't yet.

Two paths that only meet at checkout

I walked the flow three times — as a first-time user, as a returning user moving fast, and deliberately trying to break it (removing an ingredient, checking what happens to the nutrition data). The structural finding shapes everything below: **Home and Healthy are two parallel discovery paths** that don't share information, and a user has to choose between them at the very first tap.

Home (default tab, where most sessions start) — no nutrition data shown anywhere by default. Bottom nav: **Home** | Healthy | Dining

Path A — Home

1. Search
2. Restaurant list
3. Menu
4. Item
5. Cart
6. Checkout
7. Tracking

Drop-off risk: zero health signal the whole way — goal-aware users get no support here

Path B — Healthy

1. Search
2. Curated high-protein cards (kcal shown on card)
3. Browse by macro range
4. Restaurant
5. Item detail (full macro breakdown)
6. Customise item — drop-off risk: nutrition data goes missing on customisation
7. Cart
8. Checkout (Gold + coupons + Gaana upsell) — drop-off risk: goal framing competes with growth offers
9. Tracking

If a user opens the app the normal way — taps Home, searches, orders — they never see a calorie number unless they deliberately switch tabs first. This isn't a feature-quality problem. It's a feature-placement problem.

Zones, intents, and the evidence

Five screens, annotated in depth, from 17 captured on a live order (Gaur City 2, Ghaziabad). Each pin is tagged by the intent it serves, and each table row answers why the element is here, in this exact form, at this exact weight. Six intents, defined once here and used consistently below:

● **Orient** — tells the user where they are or what's happening

● **Reassure** — reduces the perceived risk of the next step

● **Retain** — pulls the user back for a future session

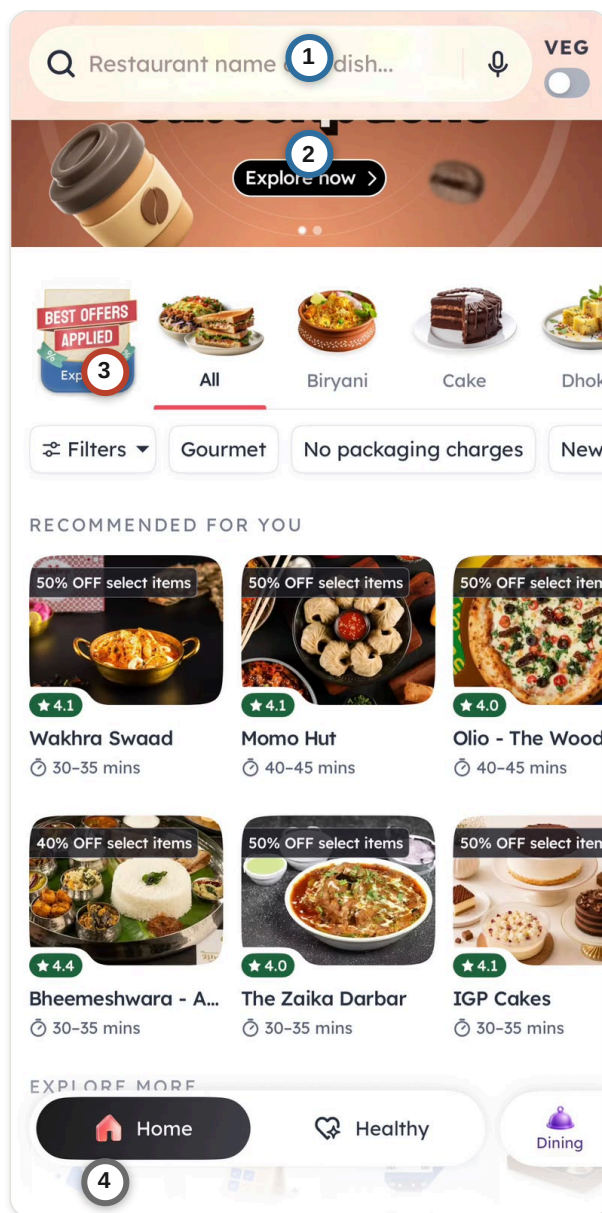
● **Progress** — moves the user toward the task they came to do

● **Extract** — captures value for the business

● **Comply** — exists because policy, legal risk, or self-protection requires it

4.1 — Home tab: the default entry point

Zones on this screen: System (status bar, search) · Content (restaurant cards) · Navigation (bottom tab bar) · Peripheral (discount badges). No dedicated health content zone exists here at all — that absence is itself the finding.



#	ELEMENT	INTENT	WHY HERE / NOW / THIS FORM / THIS WEIGHT
1	Search bar	● Orient	Top of screen, first thing seen — standard entry point for a directed search, matching Jakob's Law (every delivery app puts search here).
2	Category tabs (All/Biryani/Cake)	● Orient	Sits right below search so a user can narrow before typing anything — progressive disclosure of the catalogue.
3	"50% OFF" badge on cards	● Extract	Top-left corner of every card, high-contrast — Von Restorff effect, the badge is designed to be the first thing the eye lands on, ahead of the dish itself.
4	Bottom nav (Home / Healthy / Dining)	● Orient	Persistent navigation zone — but its real effect is that Healthy is filed as a <i>destination</i> , not a <i>lens applied to Home</i> . That's a placement decision with consequences for every screen that follows.

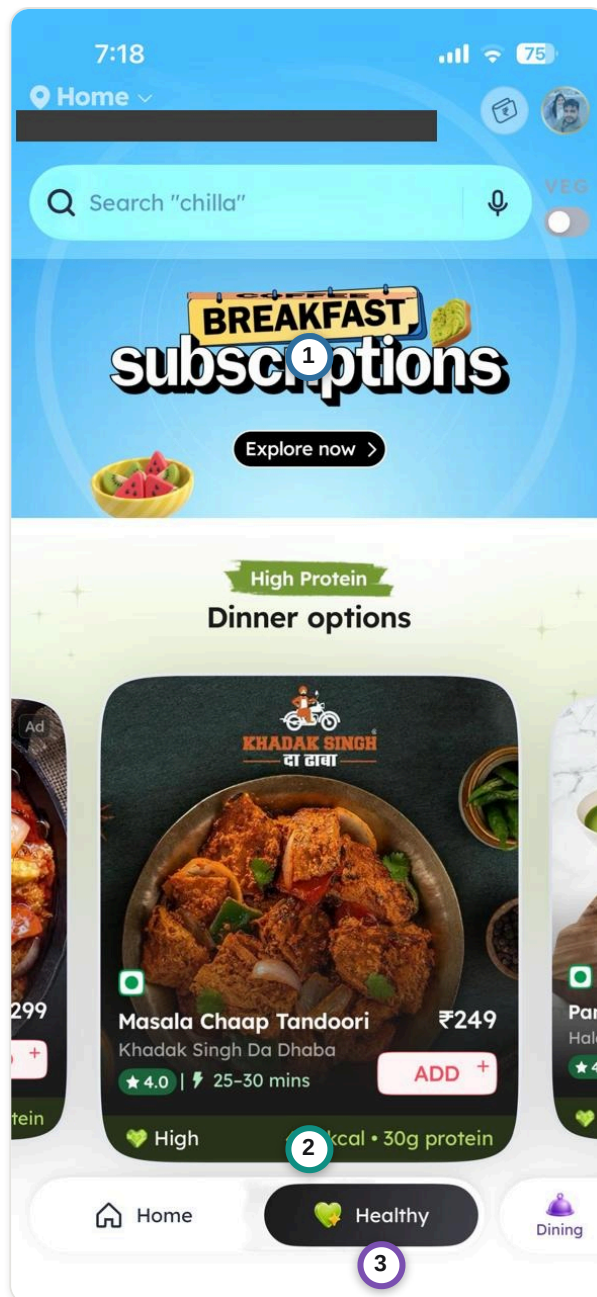
The single most interesting decision on this screen: nutrition data was placed one tab away instead of woven into this feed. The likely reason is organisational — Healthy is probably a separate initiative with its own roadmap, not a redesign of Home. I'd still change it, because it means the feature only reaches users who already know to look for it. I'd be wrong if data showed most Healthy-tab traffic comes from Home users switching tabs mid-session rather than users who'd never engage at all — that would mean placement isn't actually costing reach.

"I have to search healthy by restaurant name and pictures, but today I see at the bottom right corner it mentions 'healthy' — that's also not clearly visible to the customer even after searching. Healthy food — they're not actually healthy, so completely no sense."

— a client I work with on a structured nutrition plan, six months in

4.2 — Healthy tab: where the real feature lives

Zones on this screen: Content zone is doing far more work here than on Home — kcal/protein figures are embedded directly into each card rather than left to a peripheral banner.



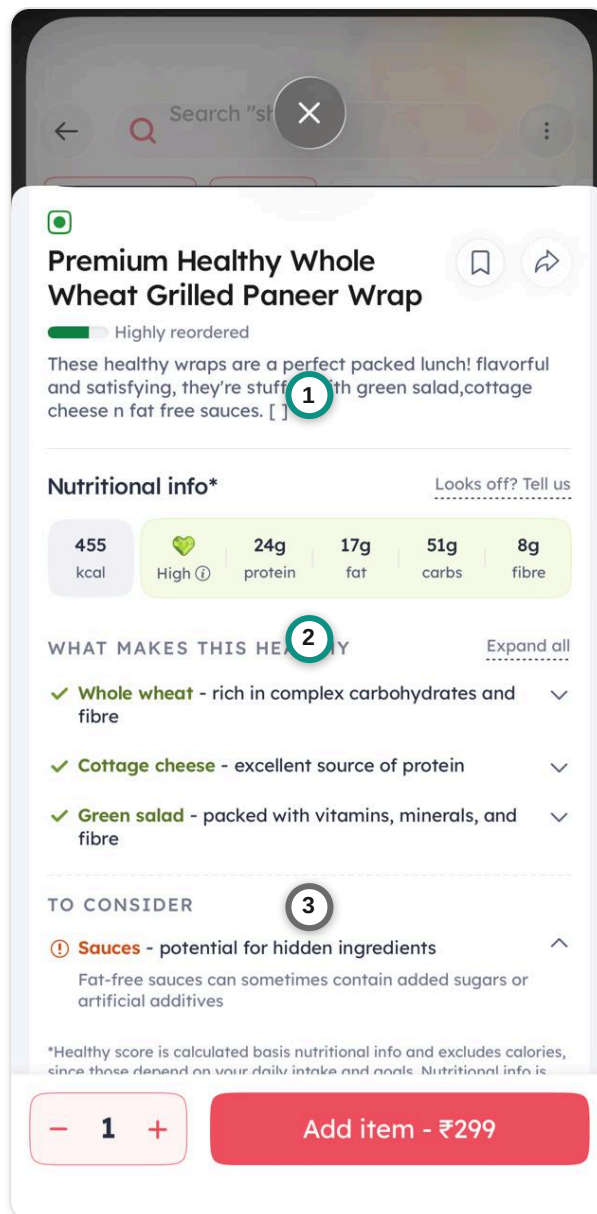
#	ELEMENT	INTENT	WHY HERE / NOW / THIS FORM / THIS WEIGHT
1	"Breakfast subscriptions" banner	● Retain	First thing shown even on a health-focused tab — a recurring-order commitment device, prioritised above the actual macro content below it.
2	Kcal + protein badge on food card ("445 kcal · 30g protein")	● Reassure	Placed at the bottom of the card, in the same visual weight as the price — the team clearly wants this treated as decision-relevant data, not decoration, and the form (plain text figures) supports fast scanning over a badge or icon.
3	Healthy tab, active state in nav	● Retain	Confirms the user is in the "second app" — reinforces the split flagged in the flow map above.

Genuine product investment here — but every badge shows the identical number to every user. 445 kcal is labelled the same for someone on a 1,600 kcal deficit and someone on a 3,200 kcal surplus. Sophisticated labelling, not personalisation.

The single most interesting decision on this screen: a Retain-intent subscription banner outranks the Reassure-intent macro data in visual priority, even on the one tab built for goal-driven users. The likely reason is that subscriptions are a stronger, more provable revenue lever than a browse feature. I'd still swap their order for returning Healthy-tab users specifically, because the banner has nothing to do with why they opened this tab in the first place.

4.3 — Item detail: nutrition reasoning

Zones on this screen: Content zone expands to include an explanatory sub-section ("What makes this healthy") that most delivery apps don't attempt — closer to a Reassure zone doing double duty as an education zone.



#	ELEMENT	INTENT	WHY HERE / NOW / THIS FORM / THIS WEIGHT
1	Nutritional info row (455 kcal, protein/fat/carbs/fibre)	● Reassure	Placed directly under the dish description, before scrolling — the number a goal-tracking user needs first, weighted equally with the dish name itself.
2	"What makes this healthy" — ingredient reasoning	● Reassure	Expandable, not a wall of text by default — progressive disclosure, so a scanning user isn't punished for wanting depth.
3	"To consider — Sauces: potential for hidden ingredients"	● Comply	Self-flagged risk on the platform's own data — functions like a disclosure even though nothing legally requires it, which suggests internal awareness that the score can mislead.

The single most interesting decision on this screen: the "Looks off? Tell us" correction link (visible in the full screenshot) is an implicit admission that Zomato itself doesn't fully trust this number. Most products hide uncertainty; this one names it. I'd keep that honesty and build on it rather than removing it.

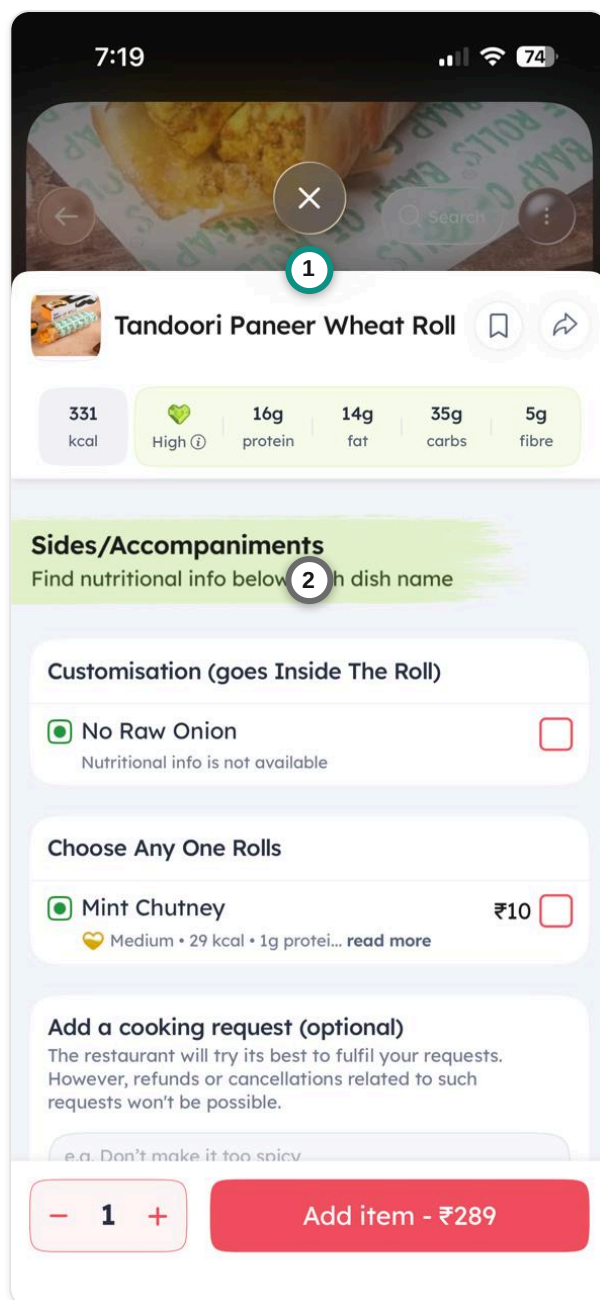
"I think of it as scam."

— Abhinav, on seeing the Healthy/EatRight section for the first time

Three words, from someone who isn't even trying to eat healthy through the app. A correction link is a good instinct — but it can't outrun a first impression like that one.

4.4 — Customisation: where the data breaks

Zones on this screen: the Content zone shows two conflicting data states in the same view — full nutrition at the top, "not available" one scroll down — a zone-level inconsistency, not just a copy issue.



#	ELEMENT	INTENT	WHY HERE / NOW / THIS FORM / THIS WEIGHT
1	Base dish nutrition (331 kcal, 16g protein)	● Reassure	Full breakdown, prominent, top of screen — consistent with every other item detail view.
2	"No Raw Onion — Nutritional info is not available"	● Comply	Functions as a disclosure, not an oversight — the platform declining to make a nutrition claim it can't support, rather than making one it can't back up. It protects the business from an inaccurate figure more than it solves the user's problem.

WHY THIS IS THE CORE FINDING

Same dish, one screen. Full nutrition at the top, "not available" the moment a common customisation is touched. This is the exact "restaurant nutrition data in India is estimate-grade,

not reliable" problem I expected conceptually — except I didn't have to argue for it. I captured it live, on my own real order.

The single most interesting decision on this screen: the team chose to show "not available" rather than silently reusing the base number. That's the more honest choice of the two — but it also means the moment a user customises, the platform quietly stops making any nutrition claim at all, on the exact interaction most orders actually involve.

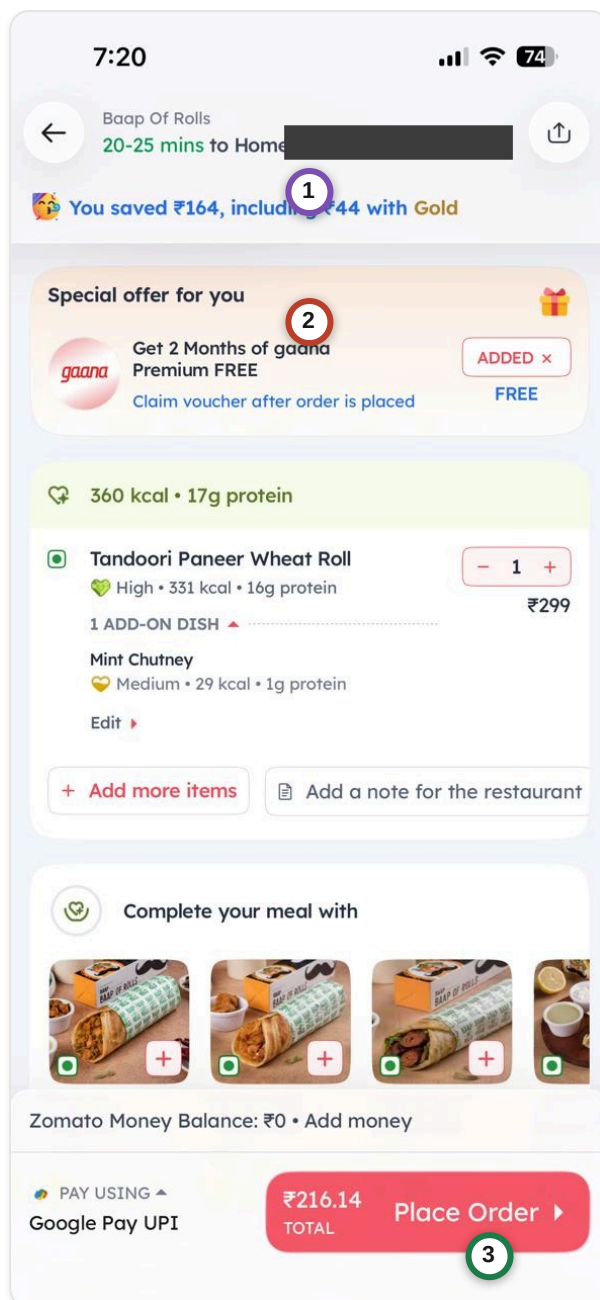
"Ordering a 'healthy' paneer or chicken wrap, only for it to arrive soaked in heavy mayo and hidden refined oil... Yes to checking the numbers, but no to trusting them — a cook's heavy hand with butter or oil easily adds 150+ unlisted calories."

— Raju, on ordering "healthy"-tagged dishes

This is the same finding from the other side of the kitchen: even a dish that would score well on paper can arrive nothing like its listed macros, because the number was never measuring the actual plate — it was measuring a recipe that a specific cook, on a specific day, doesn't have to follow.

4.5 — Checkout: Gold and the Gaana upsell

Zones on this screen: Peripheral zone (Gaana cross-sell) is placed with equal visual weight to the Action zone content around it — a genuine competition for attention right before payment.



#	ELEMENT	INTENT	WHY HERE / NOW / THIS FORM / THIS WEIGHT
1	"You saved ₹164, including ₹44 with Gold"	● Retain	Quantified, placed at the very top of the checkout scroll — reinforces subscription value at the exact moment a user is most receptive to a savings message.
2	Gaana Premium free-months offer	● Extract	Positioned directly beneath the Gold savings line, same visual weight — an unrelated cross-sell riding the trust built by the message above it.
3	"Place Order" button	● Progress	Bottom-right, thumb-reachable, filled and high-contrast against everything else on the screen — Fitts's Law and Von Restorff both at work, correctly, on the one action that matters most.

The single most interesting decision on this screen: the Gaana offer borrows the Gold banner's credibility by sitting directly beneath it. The likely reason is simple cross-sell real estate allocation — checkout is high-attention real estate and every team wants a slice. I'd still move it, because it dilutes a screen that, for this specific user, was about a health goal, not music.

STAGE 5 · FRICTION LOG

Every issue found, ranked by severity

Severity key: 5 = actively breaks the user's task or the trust in the data shown; 3 = adds friction or sends a conflicting signal; 1 = a minor inconsistency worth noting but not urgent.

SCREEN	WHAT I WAS TRYING TO DO	WHAT HAPPENED / EXPECTED	SEVERITY
Item customisation	Remove an ingredient from a healthy-tagged dish	Nutrition data disappeared entirely instead of recomputing — expected an updated estimate, not silence	5
Home tab	Order without deliberately opening the Healthy tab first	Zero macro or calorie signal anywhere on the default path	5
Healthy Score badge (any screen)	Judge whether a dish fits my specific target	Same "High/Medium" label shown regardless of my goal or what I'd already eaten that day	4
Checkout	Complete a health-conscious order	An unrelated Gaana subscription upsell appeared at the same moment as the Gold savings message	3
Nutritional info panel, fine print	Understand the Healthy Score	Fine print admits calories are excluded	3

	methodology	from the score "since those depend on your daily intake and goals" — the team already knows this, without acting on it further	
Nutritional info panel	Judge how much to trust a given number	A correction link exists ("Looks off? Tell us"), but no confidence indicator is shown before a correction happens	2

STAGE 6 · TOP THREE PROBLEMS

Impact against effort

Impact is measured against the goal set in Stage 1 — goal-awareness — not general product quality. Effort is an honest estimate of what each fix actually requires to ship.

PROBLEM	WHY IT MATTERS (IMPACT)	EFFORT	PRIORITY
No personalisation — same score for every user	This is the entire gap between labelling food and actually helping someone — everything else is downstream of this	High	P0
Health signal doesn't reach the default Home path	Most orders never touch the Healthy tab — highest-leverage fix, since the underlying data already exists	Medium	P0
Data breaks under customisation	Undermines trust in every number the app does show, the moment a user notices it once	Medium	P1

STAGE 7 · THE REBUILD

Keep, kill, change, move, add

Every verdict below names the intent it affects, the metric I'd expect to move, the trade-off it costs, and the strongest counter-argument a reasonable PM could raise against it.

VERDICT	ELEMENT	INTENT	EXPECTED METRIC IMPACT	TRADE-OFF	COUNTER-ARGUMENT
Keep	Ingredient-level "what makes this healthy" reasoning	Reassure	Improves trust/report-rate on nutrition data (fewer "looks off" flags)	Extra engineering to maintain per-ingredient copy at scale	Most users don't expand it — is the maintenance cost worth a feature few people open?
Keep	Macro-based discovery (browse by protein/kcal range)	Progress	Higher Healthy-tab session-to-order conversion	Adds filter complexity to an already dense tab	Power users like it; casual users may find it intimidating on first visit
Kill	Universal High/Medium badge as the only visible signal	Reassure (currently miscalibrated)	Should reduce mis-trust incidents once replaced by something calibrated	Removing it leaves a visual gap until the personalised version ships	The badge still has some value as a rough heuristic — killing it outright may be premature before the replacement exists
Change	Dish-level static data → ingredient-level composable data	Reassure	Should close the gap between orders with and without customisation on "looks off" reports	Requires restaurants to submit ingredient-level data, not just dish-level — real partner effort	Independent restaurants may not have the operational maturity to supply this reliably
Move	Lightweight macro signal → default Home feed and search	Reassure	Increases % of orders from health-tagged dishes	Home feed becomes visually denser for users	Could reduce Home's clarity for the majority of users who

			without a dedicated tab visit	who don't care about macros	never asked for this data there
Add	One-time goal input reweighting the existing badge	Reassure, Retain	Should raise Healthy-tab WAU/MAU as returning users see a score that reflects their own target	Adds one extra step to onboarding into the Healthy tab; goal data becomes something to store and maintain	Users may not want to disclose a health goal to a food delivery app at all — this needs to be opt- in, not mandatory

STAGE 8 · PRIORITISE AND PROVE

Experiments I'd run before shipping any of this

HYPOTHESIS	PRIMARY METRIC	GUARDRAIL	SAMPLE / DURATION	IF IT COMES BACK FLAT
If we surface a lightweight macro badge on Home feed cards for users who've visited Healthy before, then % of orders from health-tagged dishes will rise, because the signal now reaches users without requiring an extra tab switch	% of orders from health-tagged dishes — baseline unknown from outside the platform; I'd size the target against the current figure before committing to a number, and test for a meaningful relative lift rather than a fixed percentage	Overall order frequency per user must not fall	~20k users who've visited Healthy at least once, 3-week test	Most likely outcome — test whether the badge itself was seen at all (impression tracking) before concluding the signal doesn't matter to placement
If we add a one-time goal input that reweights the existing badge, then Healthy tab WAU/MAU will rise, because the score now reflects	Healthy tab WAU/MAU ratio, target +10pp	Time-to-first-order must not increase by more than a few seconds	~15k new Healthy-tab visitors, 4-week test	Re-test with the goal input made more visible/optional rather than assuming personalisation itself doesn't matter — the

something personally relevant instead of a generic label

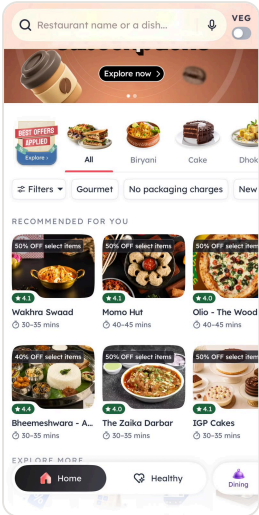
input's discoverability, not the concept, is the more likely failure point

If we recompute nutrition data live through customisation, then the "Looks off?" report rate on customised items will fall, because the number shown will actually reflect the order placed	"Looks off?" report rate on customised items, target -30% relative	Menu page load time must not slow down	All customised orders on a rolling 2-week window	Check whether report rate was already low due to under-reporting rather than accuracy — a flat result may mean the correction link itself isn't being noticed, not that the fix didn't work
---	--	--	--	---

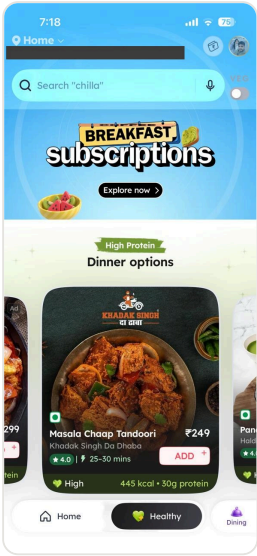
APPENDIX

Key evidence

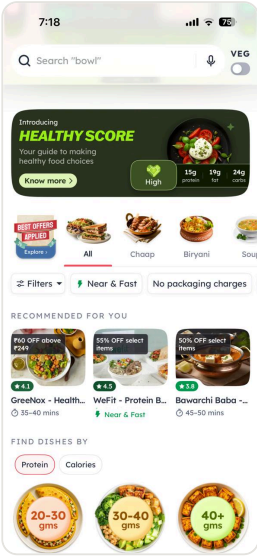
Seven screens carrying the core findings, from seventeen captured live on a personal order, Gaur City 2, Ghaziabad.



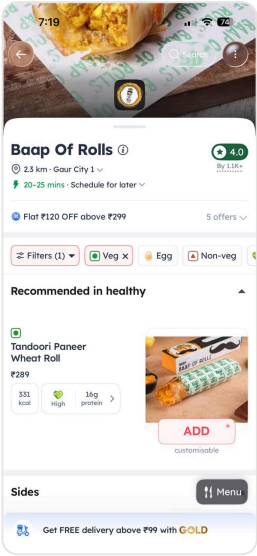
Home tab: no health signal on the default path



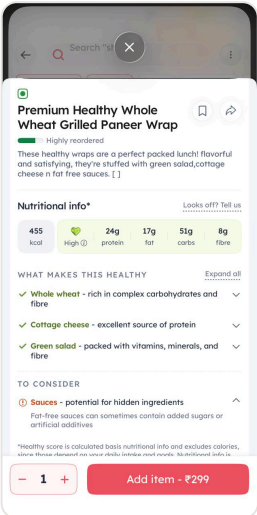
Healthy tab: macro data shown, same for every user



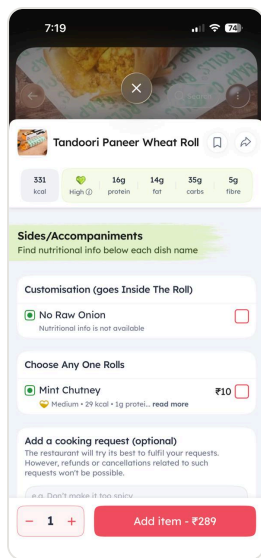
Healthy Score banner: the platform's own concept, still not personalised



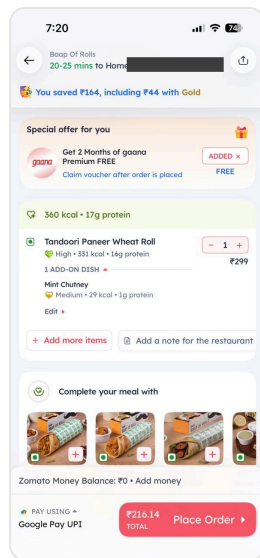
Restaurant page: health signal follows into the menu



Ingredient-level reasoning behind a Healthy tag



Nutrition data missing
after customisation — the
core finding



Checkout: Gold savings
sitting next to a Gaana
upsell

Closing note: the honest version of this teardown isn't "Zomato ignores health" — it's "Zomato built a genuinely thoughtful health feature and didn't trust it enough to put it where orders actually happen, or personalise it enough to make it more than a label."

Written self-initiated, September 2026, from seventeen screens captured on my own order.